

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 124

By Sparks

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Fire Chief William Culbertson, Jr., on the occasion of his retirement from the Smyrna Fire Department.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that we should honor those citizens who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm in securing the safety of their community; and

WHEREAS, Fire Chief William Culbertson, Jr., is one such estimable individual, who served with distinction for more than thirty years as the fire chief of the Smyrna Fire Department and will soon embark upon a much-deserved retirement; and

WHEREAS, Chief William Culbertson comes from a line of respected firefighters; his grandfather became Smyrna's first fire chief in 1924, and his father was the fire and police commissioner, vice mayor, and finance commissioner, providing a superlative example of civil service that Chief Culbertson could follow in his career; and

WHEREAS, Chief William Culbertson worked his first fire department job painting fire hydrants when he was only twelve, and he went on to graduate from Middle Tennessee Christian School and Smyrna High School; and

WHEREAS, when he was hired by the Smyrna Fire Department in 1989 after serving on a volunteer basis, Chief Culbertson became the first full-time employee in the department's history, and since his tenure's commencement, the city has grown to more than 57,400 residents, requiring the construction of five new fire stations, the renovation of two stations, and the hiring of 108 full-time personnel; and

WHEREAS, an innovator in fire service, Chief Culbertson helped found a youth camp program to familiarize children with the apparel and procedures of emergency service personnel in action, helping to instill trust in young people before any misfortune requires it; and

WHEREAS, in addition to maintaining an Insurance Services Office (ISO) score of 3, Chief Culbertson has implemented numerous community initiatives and department programs to

both enrich the town's culture and protect its people: the town's annual Independence Day Celebration and Easter egg hunt, the Fire and Police Youth Academy, the award-winning Smyrna Fire Department Honor Guard, the annual Fire Prevention Week Open House, and the annual food drive benefitting Nourish Food Bank; and

WHEREAS, he extended the department's capacity for fire prevention by hiring a fire codes and origin investigator in 2019 and then expanded that capacity even further by creating a fire codes inspector unit that currently has fifteen inspectors; the department's drone program, which began in 2021, now has twenty certified drone pilots at the department who utilize cutting-edge technology to ensure the city's safety; and

WHEREAS, under his leadership, the department assisted during the tragic United States Navy Blue Angels jet crash in 2016, collaborating with the Navy, National Guard, Tennessee Highway Patrol, and Smyrna Police Department; and

WHEREAS, apart from his work in fire service, Chief Culbertson is a passionate photographer, a skill he hopes to further develop and utilize as he plans his retirement travels; and

WHEREAS, he exemplifies the spirit and allegiance to family, especially his seven children and four grandchildren, and community that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, throughout his years in public service, Chief William Culbertson demonstrated the utmost professionalism, ability, and integrity, winning the respect and admiration of his fellow firefighters and the residents of Rutherford County; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Fire Chief William Culbertson, Jr., of the Smyrna Fire Department for his exemplary career in fire service and extend to him our heartfelt wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement and every continued success in his future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.